

Your design environment: file structure, libraries, plugins

Week 1, Lecture 2 · Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- A four-page file structure that scales without getting messy
- Team libraries: publishing, consuming, and updating components
- Three essential plugins that cover 90% of placeholder content needs
- Keyboard shortcuts that cut layout time in half

Part 1: page organization

The four-page structure

1. Cover
 , file title, last-updated date, status, owner
2. Flows
 , all screens and designs in progress
3. Components
 , main components for this file (before publishing)
4. Archive
 , old designs kept for reference, not in active use

This structure is enough for a solo project or a small team. You will find it in most professional Figma files once you look for it.

The cover page does real work

- First thing anyone sees when they open the file
- Communicates: what this file is, how current it is, who owns it
- Add a color-coded status label: Draft, In Review, Ready for Dev, Archived
- One frame, one glance

Without a cover, a file shared with a teammate or a developer starts with “wait, is this the latest version?”

Frame naming on the flows page

- Name every top-level frame: [Screen] / [State] e.g. Pricing / Default, Pricing / Annual selected
- Figma prototyping uses frame names as labels in your flows
- Dev Mode uses frame names in component inspection
- Unnamed frames become "Frame 427" which helps no one

The Figma best-practices guide (Figma, 2023) calls consistent naming "the single most important habit for working with others."

Part 2: team libraries

Local vs published components

- **Local components** live in the current file. Only that file can use them.
- **Published components** are pushed to a team library. Any file in the team can enable and use them.
- Publishing is a deliberate act: you review changes before they reach consumers

Think of publishing as merging to main. Local components are your feature branch.

Publishing a library

1. Finish and name your main components on the components page
2. Assets panel (Shift+I) → the book icon → “Publish styles and variables”
3. Write a description of what changed (this shows in the update dialog)
4. Click Publish

Consumers receive a notification in the assets panel. They choose when to accept updates. Breaking changes (renamed or deleted components) appear with a warning.

Consuming a library

1. In the target file, open the assets panel
2. Click the team library icon
3. Toggle on the library you want
4. Components appear in the assets panel under their library name
5. Drag to canvas or double-click to insert an instance

Instances stay linked to the published main component. When the library publishes an update, you see “review updates” in your file. You choose whether to apply or skip.

When a library update breaks your file

- Renamed component: instance becomes “missing component” (pink outline)
- Deleted component: same result
- Changed variant property: instances may lose their override values

Best practice (Figma, 2023): never rename a published component without giving consumers a migration window. Add a new component, deprecate the old one, remove it in a later release. This is semantic versioning for design.

Part 3: essential plugins

Iconify: every icon set in one plugin

- Access to 150,000+ icons from Lucide, Phosphor, Material, Heroicons, Tabler, and more
- Search across all sets or filter to one
- Inserts as a vector frame (fully editable)
- Choose a consistent icon style before you start: do not mix filled and outline icons in the same product

Check the license for any icon set you use in a shipped product. Lucide is ISC (free, attribution required). Phosphor is MIT. Iconify surfaces the license in the plugin panel.

Unsplash: placeholder photos without leaving Figma

- Insert a random photo or search by keyword
- Images are placed directly into a selected frame as a fill
- Unsplash license: free for commercial use, no attribution required
- Not for production: placeholder photos should be replaced before shipping

The typical workflow: set your image frames at the right dimensions, select all, run Unsplash to fill them with plausible content. Your layout review is now meaningful instead of filled with grey rectangles.

Lorem ipsum: placeholder text

- Several plugins (Content Reel, Lorem ipsum by Bram) fill text layers with realistic placeholder copy
- Useful for testing how a layout holds up under different text lengths
- Always test with: one word, a typical sentence, and a very long sentence
- Component text properties (from Lecture 1) let you override text per-instance without a plugin

A button that looks perfect with “Sign up” might overflow with “Create your free account”. Test it before you ship it.

Part 4: keyboard-driven workflow

The ten shortcuts worth learning this week

Action	Mac	Windows
Frame tool	F	F
Auto-layout: add	Shift+A	Shift+A
Component: create	Cmd+Alt+K	Ctrl+Alt+K
Group	Cmd+G	Ctrl+G
Select child	Enter	Enter
Select parent	Esc	Esc
Align left	Alt+A	Alt+A
Distribute horizontally	Ctrl+Alt+Shift+H	Ctrl+Alt+Shift+H
Rename layer	Cmd+R	Ctrl+R
Show/hide layers	Cmd+\	Ctrl+\

Why keyboard shortcuts matter more in design than in code

- You move between design and review mode constantly: every mouse trip to the toolbar is a context switch
- A professional Figma workflow is largely keyboard and right-click: the toolbar is for discovery, not daily work
- The most valuable shortcuts are not the flashy ones: they are the ones you reach for 50 times per session (frame, auto-layout, group, select parent/child)

Ziroll (Scrimba, 2022): “Once you know the shortcuts, you stop thinking about the tool and start thinking about the design.”

Building the habit

- Tape a shortcut reference card to your monitor for the first two weeks
- When you reach for the mouse to do something repetitive, pause and ask whether there is a shortcut
- The goal is not speed for its own sake: it is keeping your attention on the layout, not the interface



Design systems are for products, not for designers. The moment your components stop serving the product, they become a maintenance burden.

Take-aways

1. A four-page file structure (cover, flows, components, archive) keeps files readable for you and for anyone you share them with.
2. Publishing a team library is like merging to main: deliberate, versioned, with a window for consumers to accept updates.
3. Iconify, Unsplash, and a lorem ipsum plugin cover nearly all placeholder content needs without leaving Figma.
4. The ten keyboard shortcuts from this lecture remove the most common mouse trips. Learn them this week while the patterns are fresh.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 1 reading covers the full environment setup: frames, auto-layout, components, styles, and library workflow
- **Section (this week):** Rebuild a landing-page section pixel-for-pixel using the tools from both lectures
- **HW 1 (out this week):** Build a 12-component Figma starter kit for your product, organized with the four-page structure and published as a local library
- **Week 2:** Visual literacy: what your eye actually sees